

Dipsacus fullonum (Dipsacaceae) Teasel

Description Perennial with a spiny ridged stem growing to 6½ ft (2 m), lance-shaped leaves, and lilac-colored flowers blooming from hooked heads.

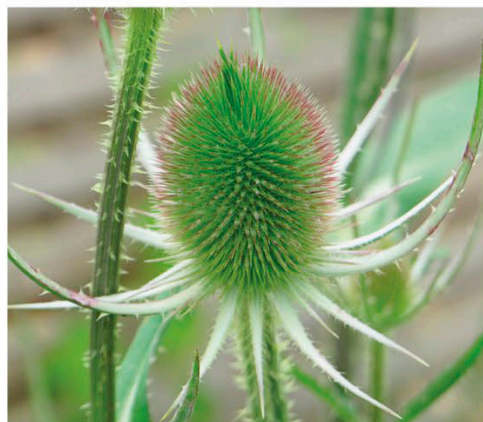
Habitat & Cultivation Common throughout Europe and western Asia, teasel thrives on open areas, roadsides, and banks. It is cultivated only on a small scale. The root is unearthed in late summer.

Part Used Root.

Constituents Teasel contains inulin, bitter substances, and a scabioside.

History & Folklore Traditionally, the root was used to treat conditions such as warts, fistulas (abnormal passages opening through the skin), and cancerous sores. The water that collects in the leaf was called “Venus’s bath” by early herbalists, and was thought to be very beneficial for the eyes.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Teasel root is little used medicinally today, and its therapeutic applications are disputed. It is thought to have diuretic, sweat-inducing, and stomach-soothing properties, cleansing the system and improving digestion. Due to its apparent astringency, teasel is considered helpful in diarrhea. It is also thought to increase appetite, to tone the stomach, and to act on the liver, helping with jaundice and gallbladder problems. A new application of teasel, so far unsubstantiated, is in the treatment of Lyme disease.



Teasel was traditionally used to treat warts and fistulas.

Dorema ammoniacum (Apiaceae) Ammoniacum

Description Very large perennial herb growing to a height of 10 ft (3 m), with a stout stem, compound leaves, and umbels of white flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Ammoniacum is native to central Asia, Iran, and northern Russia. When pierced, the stem exudes a milky gum, which is pressed into blocks and then ground into a powder.

Part Used Oleo-gum-resin.

Constituents Ammoniacum contains a resin (60–70%), gum, volatile oil (including ferulene and linalyl acetate), free salicylic acid, and coumarins.

History & Folklore Ammoniacum’s medicinal value has been appreciated since ancient times, and is mentioned by Hippocrates (460–377 BCE). The herb’s common name reputedly derives from the Temple of Jupiter Ammon in Libya, in an area where it was commonly collected.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Used in both Western and Indian medicine, ammoniacum is still listed in the *British Pharmacopoeia* as an antispasmodic and as an expectorant that stimulates the coughing up of thick mucus. It is a specific treatment for chronic bronchitis, asthma, and persistent coughs. Ammoniacum is also occasionally used to induce sweating or menstruation.

Other Species Ammoniacum is medicinally similar to asafoetida (*Ferula assa-foetida*, p. 210) and galbanum (*Ferula gummosa*, p. 211).

Dorstenia contrajerva (Urticaceae) Contrayerva

Description Stemless perennial herb growing to 1 ft (30 cm). Has palm-shaped leaves and long-stalked greenish flowers.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Central and South America and the Caribbean islands, contrayerva is generally gathered from the wild.

Part Used Rhizome.

History & Folklore Contrayerva means “antidote” in Spanish, indicating its traditional use in the treatment of poisoning and venomous bites. The herb was employed in Mayan and Aztec medicine for a variety of purposes, including as a poultice to draw pus.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Contrayerva rhizome is considered aromatic, stimulant, and sweat-inducing. Occasionally used in the early stages of serious fevers such as typhoid, it is also given for gastrointestinal problems such as diarrhea and dysentery. There is no scientific substantiation of its reputation as an antidote.

Related Species *D. convexa*, native to Zaire, is used as a wound healer; *D. klainei* is used in tropical Africa as a gargle.

Drosera rotundifolia (Droseraceae) Sundew

Description Evergreen, insectivorous perennial growing to 6 in (15 cm). Has small white flowers. The hinged, spoon-shaped leaves edged with spines secrete a sticky fluid (“sundew”), which traps insects. They are digested when the leaf closes.



Sundew was once considered a refreshing herb because it maintained its “dew” even in full sun.

Habitat & Cultivation Sundew grows in Europe, Asia, and North America, and is found in marshy ground at altitudes up to 5,900 ft (1,800 m). Formerly it was picked while in flower in summer. As it is now rare, it should not be gathered from the wild.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Sundew contains naphthaquinones, enzymes, flavonoids, and volatile oil. The naphthaquinones are antimicrobial, antispasmodic, and also cough-suppressing.

History & Folklore In the 16th and 17th centuries, sundew was thought to be a remedy for melancholy. In his *Irish Herbal* (1735), K'Eogh advised using sundew to “eat away rotten sores.”

Medicinal Actions & Uses Sundew is of greatest value in the treatment of spasmodic chest conditions such as whooping cough, bronchial asthma, and asthma. In relaxing the muscles of the respiratory tract, the plant eases breathing, relieves wheezing, and lessens the spasms of whooping cough. Commonly mixed with thyme in a syrup, sundew is a helpful remedy for coughs in children. The herb is also prescribed for gastric problems.

Echium vulgare (Boraginaceae) Viper’s Bugloss

Description Abundantly hairy perennial growing up to 3 ft (1 m). Has narrow prickly leaves and pink to violet clusters of flowers in dense spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe, viper’s bugloss is commonly found on uncultivated land, by roadsides, and in low-lying and coastal regions. The flowering tops are gathered in late summer.

Parts Used Flowering tops.

Constituents Viper’s bugloss contains pyrrolizidine alkaloids, allantoin, alkannins, and mucilage. In isolation, pyrrolizidine alkaloids are toxic to the liver. The alkannins are antimicrobial and allantoin helps wounds to heal.